

Chapter 3

Structuralism, semiology and popular culture

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THIS CHAPTER PRESENTS A discussion of structuralism and semiology. Since their emergence they have had an important effect upon the study of popular culture, and have influenced other seemingly distinct perspectives such as feminism and Marxism. Also, their concepts, such as binary oppositions, signs, signifiers, signifieds and decoding, have continued to be used in the analysis of popular culture. Unlike mass culture theory or the Frankfurt School, their legacy appears to be secure and wide ranging. Given their continued prominence it may even be premature to talk about their legacy (particularly that of semiology). They benefited from the increasing interest in theory taken by social science in the

1960s, and their reputation is said to owe something to their concern with societies which are increasingly inundated with popular culture. Here we shall outline their basic ideas, illustrate them empirically and indicate some of their limitations. However, one question which needs to be dealt with first is: What is the difference, if any, between semiology and structuralism?

If one reads the literature extensively, it becomes apparent that these terms are often used interchangeably. This suggests there is no problem because they mean the same thing. However, things are not so simple. Structuralism has been defined as a theoretical and philosophical framework relevant to the social sciences as a whole, which stresses the universal, causal character of structures. Semiology has been defined as the scientific study of sign systems such as cultures. The *Fontana Dictionary of Modern Thought* defines structuralism as 'a movement characterized by a preoccupation not simply with structures but with such structures as can be held to underlie and generate the phenomena that come under observation...with deep structures rather than surface structures... referable [according to Lévi-Strauss] to basic characteristics of the mind'. Semiology is defined as 'the general (if tentative) science of signs: systems of signification, means by which human beings— individually or in groups— communicate or attempt to communicate by signal: gestures, advertisements, language itself, food, objects, clothes, music, and the many other things that qualify' (Bullock and Stallybrass 1977:566 and 607). Structuralism claims that mental and cultural structures are universal, and that their causal effects give rise to observable social phenomena. However, semiology need not be associated with either of these claims. This is roughly the usage that will be followed in this chapter. It is not totally satisfactory because structuralism and semiology have studied the same things in similar ways. But it does suggest that semiology can be used as a method which does not endorse the universal and causal claims of structuralism.

Structural linguistics and the ideas of Saussure

The Swiss linguist Ferdinand de Saussure (1857–1913) attempted to establish and develop the discipline of structural linguistics. On the basis of this he suggested it was possible to found a science of signs.¹ In these respects, his ideas played a crucial role in the emergence of structuralism and semiology. Discussing his ideas should therefore help clarify their intentions and methods, and their relevance for studying contemporary popular culture.

Saussure is concerned with establishing linguistics as a science. To do this he makes a number of distinctions and definitions which have become familiar to anyone acquainted with the academic study of culture. Saussure's starting-point is the need to define the object of structural linguistics. For this reason, he draws a distinction between *langue* and *parole*, between language as an internally related set of differentiated signs governed by a system of rules (language as a structure) and language as used in speech or writing (language as an accomplished fact of communication between human beings). *Langue* is, according to Saussure, the object which linguists should study for it is the focus of their analyses and their principle of relevance.

Langue is the overall system or structure of a language (its words, syntax, rules, conventions and meanings). It makes the use of language (*parole*) possible and is given or taken for granted by any individual speaker. *Langue* allows people to produce speech and writing, including words and phrases which may be completely new. This idea of *langue* has proved influential because it makes it relatively easy to infer that all cultural systems, such as myths, national cultures or ideologies, may be described and understood in the same way.

Parole is defined and determined by *langue*. It is the use of language made possible by, and deriving from, *langue*. *Parole* is the sum of the linguistic units involved in speaking and writing. These cannot be studied in and of themselves as single and separate historical items. Instead, they provide

evidence about the underlying structure of langue. The aim of linguistics is to use speaking and writing to reveal the underlying structure of the language, the object of linguistics. The rules and relations of this structure can then be used to account for the particular uses people make of their language. Linguistics, therefore, involves the study of langue as a system or structure.

Structural linguistics aims to discover and scrutinise the system of grammatical rules governing the construction of meaningful sentences. These rules are not usually apparent to the users of the language who none the less can still utter or write meaningful sentences. As Saussure himself argues: 'In separating language from speaking, we are at the same time separating: (1) what is social from what is individual; and (2) what is essential from what is accessory and more or less accidental' (1974:14). From a sociological point of view it is absurd to regard speaking as an individual, non-social act. But for structural linguistics and its subsequent followers, Saussure is distinguishing between fundamental and contingent social and cultural structures, between those structures which provide the explanation and those which need to be explained.

The second distinction Saussure introduces is that between the signifier and the signified. According to Saussure, any linguistic sign, such as a word or phrase, can be broken down into these two elements of which it is composed. It is a distinction which can only be recognised analytically, not empirically, and is a function of langue rather than parole. It accounts for the capacity of language to confer meaning, a feature which has made it attractive for analysing cultural structures other than language (see, for example, Barthes's semiology below). For Saussure, the meaning of particular linguistic units is not determined by an external material reality which imposes itself upon language. These units do not have a direct referent in the external, material world. This world exists but the meanings which are conferred upon it by language are determined by the meanings inherent in

language as an objective structure of rules and relations. The meanings conferred by language arise from the differences between linguistic units which are determined by the overall system of language.

The linguistic sign is made up of the signifier and the signified. Words such as 'dog' or 'god' do not acquire their meaning from their equivalents in the world outside language but from the way language contrasts them through its ordering of the letters. In the linguistic sign, the signifier is the 'sound image', the word as it is spoken or written down, and the signified is the concept of the object or idea which is being referred to by the sign. With the examples of 'dog' and 'god', the letters you see or the sounds you hear are the signifiers, and the object and idea evoked by these sounds and words are the signifieds. A letter change can therefore give us an entirely different concept. Language confers meaning on both of the examples through their linguistic differences and their place in the differentiated categories of animals and supernatural beings.

Since the meanings of particular linguistic signs are not externally determined but derive from their place in the overall relational structure of language, it follows that the relationship between the signifier and signified is a purely arbitrary one. There is no necessary reason as to why the notation 'dog' should refer to that specific animal nor 'god' to a supernatural deity. There is no intrinsic, natural or essential reason why a particular concept should be linked with one sound image rather than another. Therefore, it is not possible to understand individual linguistic signs in a piecemeal, ad hoc or empiricist fashion. They have, rather, to be explained by showing how they fit together as arbitrary signs in an internally coherent system or structure of rules and conventions. These signs cease to be arbitrary and become meaningful once they are located within the general structure of the language. They are only properly understood when placed in this structure. This structure is what Saussure calls

langue, and it is not given but has to be reconstructed analytically.

These ideas are fundamental to the development of semiology as a way of studying popular culture. However, the relationship between signifiers and signifieds is not arbitrary in culture as it is in language. According to semiology and structuralism, there are necessary factors linking conventions, codes and ideologies which ensure the association of specific signifiers with specific signifieds.

Saussure argues that if languages are seen as systems, they can only be studied and understood in relational terms. The same argument applies to cultures if they are seen as systems. For structural linguistics, structuralism and semiology, meaning can only be derived from a general objective structure of rules in which particular units are differentiated from each other, and derive their meaningful character from their place in this structure. This structure is not given empirically but has to be discovered and defined in relational terms.

Language can be discovered and defined as a system, for Saussure, if the linguistic signs of parole are studied, not as distinct, individual items, but as signs of the structure of langue. There are two types of relationship within this system which Saussure considers important: syntagmatic relationships between units in a linguistic sequence, say words following each other in a sentence; and paradigmatic relationships between units which might replace each other in a sequence, say substituting one word for another in a sentence. To define any unit or sign in this manner is to specify its relation to other units or signs which can be combined with it to form a sequence, or which are different from it and can replace it in sequences. In either case, it is the relational character of the structure which enables the unit or sign to acquire meaning. This helps explain why structural linguistics has been influential because it suggests that other cultural systems can be analysed in the way Saussure analyses language.

The final distinction Saussure makes is between synchronic and diachronic analysis. He argues that if the task of linguistics is to reconstruct the langue which makes speech and writing possible at any particular point in time, then synchronic analysis has to be kept separate from diachronic analysis. Synchronic analysis refers to the study of structures or systems at a particular point in time, while diachronic analysis involves the study of structures or systems over time. In Saussure's linguistics, synchronic analysis entails the reconstruction of the system of language as a relational whole which is distinguished from, but not necessarily subordinated to, the diachronic study of the historical evolution and structural changes of particular linguistic units and signs. To mix the two would undermine the attempt to define the relational structure of a language. Language is seen as a system of interrelated signs which are made meaningful by their place in the system rather than by their place in history. Freezing the system assimilated by speakers and writers at one point in time allows its structural and relational character to be clearly identified without being obscured by contingent and incidental historical circumstances. Saussure seems to suggest that the structure of langue can be more easily established if synchronic and diachronic analyses are kept separate. But he has been criticised, as have structuralism and semiology, for emphasising synchronic analysis and neglecting historical and social change.

Saussure regards linguistics as a sub-branch of semiology. He suggests that semiology is a science which studies the life of signs within society, shows what they are composed of, and discovers the laws which govern them. Language can be studied as a semiological system of signs which make communication possible and meaningful. It can be clarified further by being compared with other systems of signs. Structural linguistics is one of the first stages in the development of semiology. In making his case, Saussure laid the foundations for later attempts to use structuralism and semiology to study other systems such as popular culture.

Structuralism, culture and myth

The type of linguistics developed by Saussure has not gone unchallenged, and it is not the only way that language has subsequently been studied. Saussure's ideas are important because, as we shall see, they have influenced the development of structuralism and semiology. However, they have attracted a number of criticisms.² For example, his definition of parole has been rejected for a number of reasons. Speech and writing are social rather than individual activities, langue is only ever apparent in parole anyway, and the social nature of speech and writing makes them change, unlike langue. Only the latter is social, and change a relatively minor detail in Saussure's theory. He also tends to regard human beings as little more than mouthpieces for the rules of language which govern their speech and writing. Fairclough notes that 'language varies according to the social identities of people in interactions, their socially defined purposes, social setting, and so on. So Saussure's individualistic notion of parole is unsatisfactory' (1989:21).

Fairclough criticises Saussure's theory by stressing the links between language and power. He asks if there is such a thing as language in the 'unitary and homogeneous sense' which Saussure says it possesses. According to Fairclough, the English language in the United Kingdom, for example, usually means 'British standard English', which resulted from 'the economic, political, and cultural unification of modern Britain'. Despite Saussure's argument, languages, including English, 'appear to be the products of social conditions specific to a particular historical epoch' (ibid.). Langue may be studied for its formal properties but cannot be understood apart from its particular uses, independently of parole. If this is so, it questions the distinction Saussure draws between them. Notwithstanding these criticisms, Saussure's work has significantly influenced the development of structuralism and semiology. Fairclough himself retains a distinction of sorts between langue and parole when he refers to the 'underlying social conventions' and the 'actual use' of language (ibid.: 22).

Our discussion of structuralism will begin with Lévi-Strauss's concept of structure.³ The French social anthropologist Claude Lévi-Strauss (b. 1908) is well known for introducing the concepts and methods of structuralism into anthropology, and using them for studying the myths circulating in pre-industrial societies. His version of structuralism is concerned with uncovering the common structural principles underlying specific and historically variable cultures and myths. These structural principles involve the logical and universal characteristics of the human mind which lie behind, classify and produce the empirical examples of cultural myths which can be discovered. This idea of structure is theoretical and explanatory. In the first instance, it has little to do with empirical reality, but it causes the things we can see. It is not directly available to observation, and lies behind, while producing, what we can view. The relationship pictured here by Lévi-Strauss is similar to the one Saussure draws between *langue* and *parole*.

This structure is unobservable and causal, which means its power must be unconscious. Human beings subject to this structure and its power are unaware or unconscious of its influences; in much the same way, the speakers or writers of a language are unaware or unconscious of its rules but can still use them correctly. Moreover, consciousness often involves the misrecognition of underlying structural causes and is a poor guide to their defining characteristics. The perceptions of human beings are as likely to misconceive as reveal these characteristics, and it falls to structuralist analysis to say what they are.

Structuralism can do this because it is able to construct a relational model of what this underlying structure is like, even if it cannot be verified directly by empirical observation. According to structuralist analysis, a model of the underlying reality has to be constructed in which all the parts of this structure are systematically related to each other in the same way that all the units of a language are related to each other. In both cases, parts and units acquire their distinctive

meanings as a result of their position in a relational whole. For structuralism, structures such as language and culture are more than the sum of their parts. It thus argues that things cannot be studied in their empirical isolation but only in their structural unity.

Structuralism's picture of this is of an underlying, unobservable, unconscious, universal, relational, but real and causal structure. It is defined more precisely by Lévi-Strauss as a logical grid of binary oppositions, combining rational modes of classification. It consists of a determinable number of related elements or oppositions which can be combined or classified in a finite number of ways. All types of culture represent different empirical combinations or symbolic reconciliations of inherent logical oppositions. Empirical cases are secondary expressions or temporary reconciliations of basic structural oppositions; they represent the logical transformations of the structure of oppositions inherent in the human mind. Lévi-Strauss argues that:

If the general characteristics of the kinship systems of given geographical areas, which we have tried to bring into juxtaposition with equally general characteristics of the linguistic structures of those areas, are recognised by linguistics as an approach to equivalences of their own observations, then it will be apparent...that we are much closer to understanding the fundamental characteristics of social life than we have been accustomed to think.... We shall be in a position to understand basic similarities between forms of social life, such as language, art, law, and religion, that on the surface seem to differ greatly. At the same time, we shall have the hope of overcoming the opposition between the collective nature of culture and its manifestations in the individual, since the so-called 'collective consciousness' would, in the final analysis, be no more than the expression, on the level of individual thought and behaviour, of certain time and

space modalities of the universal laws which make up the unconscious activity of the mind.

(1963:65 and 21)

A few examples may help clarify this argument. In his study of totemism (1969), Lévi-Strauss spells out his method of working. Totemism refers to the use of types of animals or other 'natural' phenomena to represent a specific social group, say a clan or a tribe. According to Lévi-Strauss, totemism cannot be explained by any particular example since there is no necessary reason why certain totems should represent certain groups. He rejects utilitarian and functional explanations and says that the relationship between the group, the signified and the totem, the signifier, is arbitrary. What he argues instead is that the empirically observable phenomenon is only one possible combination which exists alongside other logical possibilities. These can be discovered if the overall relational structure of possibilities and transformations is constructed. By following this procedure, totemism becomes intelligible.

The theory presumes that totemism is an empirical sign of the fundamental and universal tendency of societies to classify socio-cultural things, such as groups or tribes, by means of things which are natural, such as animals or plants. Lévi-Strauss constructs a grid of binary oppositions and possible permutations based on two assumptions: that totemism provides a non-social (natural) representation of the social (cultural) which is both individual and collective; and that the natural consists of categories and particulars, and the cultural of groups and persons. As a result, totemism is located within the possible combinations of the logically related oppositions between collective and individual existence, and culture and nature. It is intelligible as one way of transforming the elements contained in the following grid (Lévi-Strauss 1969: 84-85):

Nature	Category	Particular
Culture	Group	Person

These collective and individual expressions of the binary opposition between culture and nature can be combined and transformed into a number of distinct relational types as follows (ibid.):

	1	2	3	4
Nature	Category	Category	Particular	Particular
Culture	Group	Person	Person	Group

Totemism is thus understood, not as a distinct empirical phenomenon to be found only in certain cultures, but as a number of different types which stem from this classificatory structure of logical oppositions and possible transformations. Lévi-Strauss identifies totemism empirically with types 1 and 2, and says it is only indirectly related to types 3 and 4. It consists of certain relations and types which can be explained only when the complete structure, of which they are among the other possible combinations, has been reconstructed. It is this universal and underlying structure, organising the opposition between culture and nature, which gives rise to totemism, and allows other possible transformations to occur.

Totemism also provides a symbolic reconciliation of the opposition between culture and nature because they are united by the totem which represents them both. It is an empirical symbol through which societies and their cultures mediate the universal relationship between culture and nature. Other symbols can be analysed by other universal oppositions, such as those between good and evil, and the sacred and the profane.⁴

Another helpful example of structuralism is Lévi-Strauss's study of myths. In *Structural Anthropology*, Lévi-Strauss mentions a myth to be found among the Iroquois and Algonquin indians of North America which, he suggests, closely resembles the Oedipus legend. The story concerns incest between brother and sister rather than mother and son, and murder, although not the unwitting slaying by a son of his father; however, it does contain the moral that attempts to

prevent incest make it inevitable. In looking at elements of these two myths he asks the questions: 'Is this a simple coincidence—different causes explaining that, here and there, the same motifs are arbitrarily found together? Or are there deeper reasons for the analogy? In making the comparison, have we not put our finger on a fragment of a meaningful whole?' (1977:21). His answer to the last question is yes. However, he provides a test of his theory based on the observation that the native north American myth lacks the riddle to be found in the Oedipus legend. If these myths are fragments of a meaningful whole, an underlying, logical and causal structure, then a riddle, suitably transformed, should also be found in north American myth.

This is indeed what Lévi-Strauss discovers. He points out that riddles, such as that associated with the Sphinx episode in the Oedipus myth, are almost entirely absent among the 'North American Indians'. So if such a riddle could be found it would show he has uncovered 'a fragment of a meaningful whole' that was not 'the effect of chance, but proof of necessity' (*ibid.*: 22). He says that among native north American myths only two types of riddles can be found: one where they are told to audiences by clowns whose birth is the result of incest; and one, to be found among the Algonquins, where owls ask riddles 'which the hero must answer under pain of death' (*ibid.*; this is the dilemma Oedipus finds himself in when confronted by the Sphinx). In the myth Lévi-Strauss started with, the incestuous brother, the hero of the myth, murders his double whose mother is a sorceress, a mistress of the owls. This means that we have a transformation of both the incestuous relationships, sister—brother, mother—son, and of the riddle which 'present a double Oedipal character, by way of incest on the one hand, and on the other hand, by way of the owl in which we are led to see, in a transposed form, an American Sphinx' (*ibid.*).

Again Lévi-Strauss has discovered meaningful relations between elements and oppositions—incest and riddles—which are transformed from one myth to another. These, in

turn, suggest other possible relations, arising as they do from an underlying and universal mental structure which 'thinks' these relations and oppositions. He pursues, for example, the possible permutations of riddles with each other, those questions which have no answer and those answers which have no question. This takes him on to the death of Buddha and the Holy Grail cycle, where questions which should be asked are not. He also looks at the relations between sexuality represented by incest, and chastity represented by the heroes of myths, and tries to locate Oedipal type myths within a wider structure of possibilities. The point of these examples is to unravel the meaningful and logically based mental whole which lies behind them.

This argument is given additional force since it uncovers a structure which manages to prevail irrespective of the influences exerted by specific historical, social or cultural conditions. As Lévi-Strauss concludes: 'it seems that the same correlation between riddles and incest exists among peoples separated by history, geography, language and culture' (*ibid.*: 24). Comparable transformations of myth can be found in societies as far apart from each other, and as structurally distinct, as native north American tribes and the city states of ancient Greece. If this is so, the specific features of these societies cannot explain the character of myths. Instead, they are explained by the logical structure of the human mind which accounts for the similarities and transformations detected by structuralism in cultural myths. In a fitting conclusion to his discussion of these myths, Lévi-Strauss writes:

we have only sketched here the broad outlines of a demonstration...to illustrate the problem of invariance which, like other sciences, social anthropology attempts to resolve, but which it sees as the modern form of a question with which it has always been concerned—that of the universality of human nature.

(*ibid.*)

He consequently argues that, as a science, structuralism investigates 'a system ruled by an internal cohesiveness' which is 'inaccessible to observation in an isolated system', but which is 'revealed in the study of transformations through which similar properties are recognized in apparently different systems' (ibid.: 18).

Structuralism and James Bond

Umberto Eco's study of the James Bond novels written by Ian Fleming provides a structuralist analysis of contemporary popular culture. While this does not share all the presuppositions held by Lévi-Strauss, its evaluation can show us how structuralism studies contemporary popular culture, and indicate some of the limitations it confronts. A leading contemporary Italian intellectual and semiologist, Eco (b. 1932) is well known as a popular novelist as well as for his studies of popular culture. His study of the Bond novels is perhaps the best known example of his attempt to apply the methods of structuralism to the study of popular culture.⁵

Eco's concern is to uncover the invariant rules governing the narrative structure of these novels. These rules ensure the popular success of the novels and their appeal to a cultural elite. As popular culture, the novels are based upon an underlying structure of rules which makes them popular. For Eco, these rules are comparable to 'a machine that functions basically on a set of precise units governed by rigorous combinational rules. The presence of these rules explains and determines the success of the "007" saga—a success which, singularly, has been due both to the mass consensus and to the appreciation of more sophisticated readers' (1979:146). This 'narrative machine' presumably connects at some unconscious level with the desires and values of the popular audience, for each cog or 'structural element' of which this machine is composed, is assumed to be related to 'the reader's sensitivity' (ibid.).

Eco constructs the series of oppositions upon which the novels are based. These oppositions, which are very similar to

Lévi-Strauss's binary oppositions, can be combined and recombined with each other, and are 'immediate and universal' (ibid.: 147). Their 'permutation and interaction' means that the combination, association and representation of each opposition can be varied, to some extent, from novel to novel. None the less, they form an invariant structure of oppositions which defines the narratives and ensures the popularity of the novels. These oppositions involve the relations between characters in the novels (for example, between Bond and the villain or the woman), the relations between ideologies (for example, between liberalism and totalitarianism, or the 'free world' and the 'Soviet Union') and a larger number of relations between distinct types of values (for example, 'cupidity—ideals, love—death, chance—planning... perversion—innocence, loyalty-disloyalty' (ibid.)). These relationships are worked out by particular characters, the relations between characters and the unravelling of the story as a whole. For example, Bond, in his relations with the villain, represents the ascendancy of the free world over the Soviet Union, and the victory of chance over planning. But whatever the specific transformation of relations between oppositions in particular novels, the underlying structure of oppositions remains the same. Eco traces the nature of this structure and its transformations across the stories to be found in the James Bond novels.

This argument is linked to the idea that there is an invariant sequential structure underlying the novels. Eco compares this to 'play situations' or 'games' in which each initial 'move' gives rise to a countermove and so on, pushing the story forward. The prevalence of games of chance in the novels occurs 'because they form a reduced and formalized model of the more general play situation that is the novel. The novel, given the rules of combination of oppositional couples, is fixed as a sequence of "moves" inspired by the code and constituted according to a perfectly prearranged scheme' (ibid.: 156). Abbreviating slightly, this 'invariable scheme' can be detailed as follows:

- A M moves and gives a task to Bond;
- B Villain moves and appears to Bond...;
- C Bond moves and gives a first check to Villain or Villain gives first check to Bond;
- D Woman moves and shows herself to Bond;
- E Bond takes Woman...;
- F Villain captures Bond...;
- G Villain tortures Bond...;
- H Bond beats Villain...;
- I Bond, convalescing, enjoys Woman, whom he then loses.

(ibid.)

This scheme is invariant in that each novel must contain all these elements or 'moves'. It is demanded by the narrative structure of the novels and explains their popular success. However, these basic elements need not appear in this sequence. In fact, Eco goes to great lengths to show the range of variations possible. In this sense, paradigmatic relations are more fundamental to the structure which articulates the novels than syntagmatic relations. The sequence may change but the structure remains the same. And it does so, as Eco tries to demonstrate, irrespective of the many 'side issues' or incidental features which may be introduced to add colour and variety to any particular novel.

According to Eco, the coming together of these two structures of binary oppositions and premeditated moves accounts for the popular attractions of the novels. The incidental features or 'collateral inventions' play their part in this success, especially among more 'sophisticated' readers. Eco suggests that 'the true and original story remains immutable, and suspense is stabilized curiously on the basis of a sequence of events that are entirely predetermined'. As such, 'there is no basic variation, but rather the repetition of a habitual scheme in which the reader can recognize something he has already seen and of which he has grown fond.' This means that 'the reader finds himself immersed in a game of which he knows the pieces and the rules—and perhaps the

outcome—and draws pleasure simply from following the minimal variations by which the victor realizes his objective' (ibid.: 160).

This argument is interesting because it combines the concepts of structuralism with a picture of the audience consistent with that presented by the mass culture critics and the Frankfurt School. As Eco continues, 'the novels of Fleming exploit in exemplary manner that element of foregone play which is typical of the escape mechanism geared for the entertainment of the masses' (ibid.: 161). A theory which relies upon the concept of an underlying and unconscious structure for its explanatory power is clearly liable to underestimate the significance of the role of the audience in understanding popular culture.⁶ This view is evident in Eco's account of Fleming's use of ideology. He argues that the ideologies to be found in the novels are determined by the demands of mass culture. Fleming's reliance on cold war ideology, for example, derives simply from his endorsement of 'the common opinions shared by the majority of his readers' (ibid.). Eco suggests that 'Fleming seeks elementary oppositions; to personify primitive and universal forces, he has recourse to popular standards' (ibid.: 162).

Another aspect of Eco's structuralism, one consistent with that of Lévi-Strauss, concerns the universal character of the structure which lies behind and explains the popularity of the Bond novels. Eco argues that the narrative structure of these novels represents a modern variation on the universal theme of the struggle between good and evil. This struggle, which for Eco defines Fleming's Manichaeian ideology even if it is the result of opportunism, forms a fundamental binary opposition. The Bond novels are comparable to fairy tales in which a knight (Bond), under the orders of a king (M), goes on a mission to destroy the monster, such as a dragon (the villain), and rescue the lady (the woman). Both types of story involve transformations of the basic elements embodied in the binary opposition between good and evil. They express a universal structure of basic oppositions which, because it is

universal, will ensure popular success. Both the Bond novels and fairy tales are successful because they are universal in their underlying connection with the eternal conflict between good and evil.

The popular success of the Bond novels is accounted for by the idea that the mass audience is unknowingly in tune with the universal themes which are evoked. For this mass readership, 'it is clear how the novels of Fleming have attained such a wide success: they build up a network of elementary associations to achieve something original and profound' (ibid.: 163). However, there are more discerning readers who are conscious of the mechanics of the novels, and capable of grasping the more subtle and esoteric allusions in Fleming's writing (ibid.). Eco is here identifying a culturally stratified audience for the Bond novels, one divided between the mass popular readership, and a cultural elite. He thus elaborates upon the references to be found in the novels which appeal to the tastes of the culturally literate reader. He notes, for example, the resemblance between the physical description of James Bond and that of a typical Byronic hero (ibid.: 171-172 and 169-170). Moreover, 'the sophisticated readers' can 'distinguish, with a feeling of aesthetic pleasure, the purity of the primitive epic impudently and maliciously translated into current terms'. They can also 'applaud in Fleming the cultured man, whom they recognize as one of themselves, naturally the most clever and broadminded' (ibid.: 163).

Eco's structuralism leads him to argue that the structure of the novels places particular types of readers, masses and elites, in particular types of attraction, elemental primitivism and cultural sophistication. In view of this, it is curious that Eco finally comes to recognise the importance of readers who are not determined in their reading by the structure of the text. He argues that 'since the decoding of a message cannot be established by its author, but depends on the concrete circumstances of reception, it is difficult to guess what Fleming is or will be for his readers' (ibid.: 172). But without this 'definitive verification' what is the point of the analysis

Eco has carried out? If it is the reception of the novels by their readers which determines their meaning, then what is the point of uncovering their invariant structure of binary oppositions? What value do structuralist analyses have if cultural meanings are derived from the 'society that reads', from 'the concrete circumstances of reception'? These circumstances are socially and historically specific patterns of cultural production and consumption, not invariant narrative structures or binary oppositions. To suggest that the influence exerted by the universal structure does not determine how and why people read the texts which it generates, is to call into question the value of structuralist analyses. This is all the more surprising since Eco starts from the assumption that identifying this structure will account for the popularity of the texts being studied.

There is some confusion here over the role of readers or audiences. Are the 'readings' of audiences determined by a universal structure, or by social, cultural and historical conditions? Related questions raised by this point are: do audiences themselves decide upon their understandings of popular culture?; or does the analyst or theorist decide for them?; and, if so, do the latter take account of the former in arriving at their interpretations of popular culture?

This problem is intensified by the ahistorical nature of Eco's structuralist analysis. His explanatory principle is, after all, an invariant, static and eternal structure. As Bennett and Woollacott argue, there are no fixed, universal and ahistorical codes; 'readings' of popular culture are always organised in historically specific contexts. They point out how difficult it is to make sense of the James Bond novels without taking into consideration their 'intertextuality' (Bennett and Woollacott 1987: [chapter 3](#)). This means that the popular cultural phenomenon of James Bond has to be assessed in the context of the range of 'texts', or cultural forms and media outlets, in which it is to be found. These include, most significantly, the James Bond films as well as the novels. Bennett and Woollacott also argue that readers come to novels with some

prior cultural knowledge, and suggest that the codes developed in reading the British imperialist spy thriller formed an important aspect of the cultural knowledge readers brought to their interpretations of the Bond novels. They even speculate that some working-class readers would have read them in terms of the codes associated with detective fiction. Similarly, Denning argues that the emergence of codes associated with tourism and pornography in the 1960s was a crucial reference point for audiences of both the novels and the films (Denning 1987: [chapter 4](#)).

Barthes, semiology and popular culture

The semiological study of popular culture probably owes much of its reputation and importance to the writings of the French critic and semiologist Roland Barthes (1915–1980), and in particular to his book *Mythologies* (originally published in 1957). In the studies and theoretical arguments which make up this book, Barthes sets out a way of interpreting popular culture which has, with some notable revisions, been highly influential and extensively discussed ever since.⁷ Before we consider this work, some general points about Barthes's semiology and his book *Writing Degree Zero* (written before he wrote *Mythologies*) need to be considered in order to clarify his subsequent work.

Barthes, structuralism and semiology

The general points made here are comparable to those made about structuralism, except that semiology does not assume there is a universal structure underlying sign systems. The signs and codes it refers to are meant to be historically and culturally specific. It does, however, insist that it is these codes and signs which make meaning possible and enable human beings to make their world intelligible.

The wider significance of semiology can perhaps be gauged by the way Barthes later clarified his aims in writing the pieces which make up his book *Mythologies*. He writes,

I was dazzled by this hope: to give my denunciation of the self-proclaimed petit-bourgeois myths the means of developing scientifically; this means was semiology or the close analysis of the processes of meaning by which the bourgeoisie converts its historical class-culture into universal nature; semiology appeared to me, then, in its program and tasks, as the fundamental method of an ideological critique.

(1988:5)

This usefully indicates the intention of his book, even if it also hints at his subsequent reluctance to think of semiology as a systematic science.

As with structuralism, the first point which needs to be noted is that semiology is defined as a science of signs, in keeping with Saussure's original suggestion. It not only possesses a notion of ideology against which the truth of science can be measured, but it promises a scientific way of understanding popular culture. This allows it to be distinguished from the arbitrary and individualistic impressionism of liberal humanist studies of culture, as well as from those approaches which rely upon aesthetic discrimination and 'good taste'.

Semiology argues that material reality can never be taken for granted. It is always constructed and made intelligible to human understanding by culturally specific systems of meaning. This meaning is never 'innocent', but has some particular purpose or interest lying behind it, which semiology can uncover. Our experience of the world is never 'innocent' because systems of meaning make sure it is intelligible. There is no such thing as a pure, uncoded, objective experience of a real and objective world. The latter exists but its intelligibility depends upon codes of meaning or systems of signs, such as language.

These codes and signs are not universally given, but are historically and socially specific to the particular interests and purposes which lie behind them. It is in this sense that they

are never innocent. Meaning is not something which is given or which can be taken for granted. It is manufactured out of historically shifting systems of codes, conventions and signs. Semiology is concerned with this production of meaning, with what Barthes calls 'the process of signification'. Cultural meanings are not universal, nor are they divorced from the social conditions in which they are to be found. Rather, they present themselves as universal when they are really historically and socially fixed. As Barthes writes in *Mythologies*, the function of myth is to 'transform history into nature' (1973:140). This point will be clarified by Barthes's analysis of specific myths; it is also an argument advanced in his book *Writing Degree Zero* (1967; originally published in 1953).

Writing Degree Zero

In this, his first book, Barthes was concerned with the French classical style of writing. This style, which emerged in court society in the seventeenth century, prided itself upon clarity and preciseness of expression, and set itself up as a universal model or standard for all writing. By the nineteenth century, the French classical style of writing was considered to be the only correct and rational way to write, an inevitable and 'natural' style which simply and unambiguously served to reflect reality. During this period, this model of lucidity came to be legitimised as a universal model of human communication.

However, Barthes understands it in a different way. For a start, despite its supposed universal and natural qualities, from the mid-nineteenth century onwards it begins to disintegrate. In this process, it is challenged by a growing number of styles, for example, writing as a craft or job, self-conscious literariness, and 'writing degree zero'. Barthes's critique of the French classical style is based upon the reasons for this disintegration. He argues that it is wider social forces and class interests which govern the formation and transformation of writing styles. The emergence of new class

interests and conflicts in the nineteenth century results in the breakdown of the classical style. Barthes interprets this style, despite its pretensions, as an aspect of the rise of bourgeois hegemony, and thus as a 'class idiom'.

For Barthes, French classicism, irrespective of its pretensions, is neither neutral and universal nor natural and inevitable. Instead, it has to be located in its historical and social contexts. As such, it is central to the rise of bourgeois hegemony between the seventeenth and nineteenth centuries, and to the emergence of challenges to this hegemony from the 1850s onwards. According to Barthes, the classical style is rhetorical in character, motivated by the 'permanent intention to persuade'. It is the style of the law courts and the political campaign, aimed at changing opinions and ensuring the acceptance of the bourgeois view of the world. It has thus not simply been a reflection of reality but an attempt to shape conceptions of reality. It has not been neutral and universal, nor natural and inevitable, but historically specific and socially constructed, rooted in a particular set of class interests. Its meaning has not been given but produced, not 'innocent' but 'guilty'. French classicism is another 'myth', which tries to transform the historical into the natural in the interests of the bourgeois class.

This is, for Barthes, a feature of all writing. 'Writing degree zero' is a style developed in order to reject the idea of politically committed writing. It values writing which is colourless, transparent and neutral, blank and impersonal. It pretends to be as asocial and ahistorical as possible. In a way, it is not a style at all. But this is not possible according to Barthes. For him, all writing is a form of fabrication, a way of making things up, which therefore cannot avoid these signs of fabrication or style. Furthermore, all writing is ideological and cannot avoid being so. Writing is never just an instrument of communication, an open way of addressing people. It is rather a product of certain social and historical circumstances and certain power relations, and cannot escape their influence. Non-ideological writing, writing which presents

itself as being beyond ideology, is for Barthes shown to be an illusion by his investigation of French classicism and 'writing degree zero'.

Myths and popular culture

Barthes carried these ideas further in his book *Mythologies*, which contains a series of short essays on various examples of popular culture, originally published in magazines, and an outline of the concepts and methods of semiology which he uses to analyse the examples. It is the latter we shall consider first. Myths are forms of popular culture, but they are also more than this, according to Barthes. We have to find out what is really going on, and to do this we have to turn to semiology.

'Myth is a system of communication, that is a message', Barthes writes, 'a mode of signification...a type of speech... conveyed by a discourse. Myth is not defined by the object of its message, but by the way in which it utters this message' (1973: 117). This means that the concepts and procedures of semiology can be applied to the study of myths. To understand this we need to remind ourselves of the claims semiology makes. Barthes notes that 'any semiology postulates a relation between two terms, a signifier and a signified' (ibid.: 121), a distinction elaborated by Saussure, as we have seen. There is also a third term in this, the sign itself (be it linguistic or mythological), which contains the signifier and the signified. Barthes wishes to use this argument to study myth, and he gives an initial and preliminary example of how this might be done.

The case he has in mind is a bunch of roses which can be used to signify passion. Barthes asks:

Do we have here, then, only a signifier and a signified, the roses and my passion? Not even that: to put it accurately, there are here only 'passionified' roses. But on the plane of analysis, we do have three terms [even if empirically there is only one thing, the roses]; for these

roses weighted with passion perfectly and correctly allow themselves to be decomposed into roses and passion: the former and the latter existed before uniting and forming this third object, which is the sign.

(ibid.: 121–122)

In other words, the roses are a signifier of a signified, which is passion, something signified by the roses sent to a loved one. The bunch of roses can thus be analytically if not empirically broken down into a signifier, the roses, a signified, passion, and a sign which combines and is not separate from these two components, the roses as a sign of passion. Here, passion is the process of signification. This attribution of meaning—the roses signify passion and not, say, a joke or a farewell—cannot be understood simply in terms of the system of signs, but has to be located in the context of the social relationships in which the attribution of meaning occurs. However, this is a problem which semiology finds it difficult to deal with. It is similar to the problem Saussurian linguistics has in dealing with language independently of the contexts in which people actually use language.

Because the mythic process of signification is not totally comparable with that associated with language, Barthes uses other concepts to analyse myths. According to Barthes, myth 'is a second-order semiological system' (ibid.: 123). It relies upon signs in other first-order systems such as language (and horticulture, as with roses?) in order to engage in the process of signification. A sign in a first-order system, a word, a flower or a photograph, becomes a signifier in the second-order system of myth. Myth uses other systems, be they written or pictorial, to construct meanings. Myth thus becomes a metalanguage because it can refer to other languages, and requires the use of new if comparable concepts.

These concepts are established by Barthes through his most famous example. He writes:

I am at the barber's, and a copy of *Paris-Match* is offered to me. On the cover, a young Negro in a French uniform is saluting, with his eyes uplifted, probably fixed on a fold of the tricolour. All this is the meaning of the picture. But ...I see very well what it signifies to me: that France is a great Empire, that all her sons, without any colour discrimination, faithfully serve under her flag, and that there is no better answer to the detractors of an alleged colonialism than the zeal shown by this Negro in serving his so-called oppressors. I am therefore...faced with a greater semiological system: there is a signifier, itself already formed within a previous system (a black soldier is giving the French salute); there is a signified (it is here a purposeful mixture of Frenchness and militariness); finally, there is a presence of the signified through the signifier.... French imperialism.

(ibid.: 125–126 and 128)

While retaining the analytical value of the distinctions made by structural linguistics, Barthes suggests that the study of myths needs to avoid confusion. Therefore, the signifier becomes 'form', the signified 'concept' and the sign 'signification'. In the example just mentioned, we have the form of the black soldier saluting the French flag, the concept of French military strength and the signification of the grandeur and impartiality of French imperialism. All of this is in the photograph, but has to be revealed by semiological analysis.

Using these concepts and this example, Barthes argues that myth works through the relationships between form, concept and signification. The form of this specific myth of French imperialism, the black soldier, is taken from one system, his real history, which gave him his meaning, and placed in another system, that of the myth, which denies his history and culture, and thus the real history of French colonial exploitation. What motivates this 'impoverishment of meaning' is the concept of French imperialism, which gives

another history to the soldier, that of the grandeur and impartiality of French colonialism. The soldier is now made to function as a sign of French imperialism. As Barthes puts it, emphasising the process of signification: 'The French Empire? It's just a fact: look at this good Negro who salutes just like one of our boys' (ibid.: 134).

For Barthes, 'signification is the myth itself' (ibid.: 131), the coming together of form and concept in the cultural sign. But the form does not hide the concept, or make it disappear as some theories of ideology tend to insist. Barthes writes: 'myth hides nothing: its function is to distort, not to make disappear... there is no need of an unconscious in order to explain myth... the relation which unites the concept of the myth to its meaning is essentially a relation of deformation...in myth the meaning is distorted by the concept' (ibid.: 131–132). Unlike the linguistic sign, the 'mythical signification...is never arbitrary; it is always in part motivated' (ibid.: 136). This motivation of form by concept relates to the social and historical characteristics of myth.

Barthes notes that 'if one wishes to connect a mythical schema to a general history, to explain how it corresponds to the interests of a definite society—in short, to pass from semiology to ideology' (ibid.: 138), one has to become a semiologist and understand 'the very principle of myth: it transforms history into nature' (ibid.: 140). As with his analysis of French classical writing, Barthes argues that myth has to be understood by how it transforms the socially (the interests of the bourgeois class) and historically specific (the structure of capitalist societies) into something which is natural and inevitable; and which has to be accepted because it has always been the case and nothing can be done about it (for example, 'The French Empire? It's just a fact'), when it is really an historically specific structure of imperial power.

Barthes's idea that myth serves to naturalise history implies that this process influences consumers by naturalising their reactions to myth. He argues that the reader is allowed 'to consume myth innocently' because 'he does not see it as a

semiological system but as an inductive one' since 'the signifier and the signified have, in his eyes, a natural relationship'. As such, 'the myth-consumer takes the signification for a system of facts: myth is read as a factual system, whereas it is but a semiological system' (ibid.: 142).

Myth is not an unconscious process, but, according to Barthes, its consumers take it at face value, and accept it as natural and inevitable. They need semiology to tell them that myth is a system of meaning which cannot be taken for granted. The semiological interpretation of myth assumes readers will understand myth in the way the theory predicts. It does not therefore take account of how people actually interpret myth, for if myths are so effectively mystifying, how can they be so easily demystified?

Bourgeois men and women novelists

In a later work, *Elements of Semiology*,⁸ Barthes refined his understanding of the relationship between the signifier, the signified and myth by drawing a distinction between denotation and connotation. On one level, the meaning of popular cultural signs is self-evident. They are what they are or what they appear to be, an advert, a photo of a black soldier, a bunch of roses and so on. They denote something to us, they present it to us as a matter of fact: this is a photo of a soldier, an advert, a bunch of roses. Denotation refers to those things which appear to us as natural and which we can take for granted.

But the task of semiology is to go beyond these denotations to get to the connotations of the sign. Doing this reveals how myth works through particular signs, and shows how the constructed, manufactured and historical location of the myth can be discovered. The connotations of myths can thus be identified: this may appear to be a bunch of roses but it connotes passion; or this may appear to be a photo of a black soldier saluting the French flag, but it really connotes the grandeur and impartiality of French imperialism. The

methods of semiology reveal the ideologies contained in cultural myths.

Barthes is concerned with the role of myth in modern society, how it is constructed and sustains meaning as a systematic force. His intention is to get behind the process of mythical construction to reveal the real meanings which are distorted by myth. This involves moving from meanings that are taken for granted, which make things appear natural and inevitable, to meanings that are rooted in historical circumstances and class interests, moving, as he puts it, 'from semiology to ideology' (1968:139). Although there is some novelty and interest in Barthes's semiology, his theory of ideology seems more in tune with crude Marxist versions of the concept in that the myths of popular culture are viewed as serving the interests of a bourgeois class.

According to Barthes, bourgeois ideology characteristically denies the existence of a bourgeois class. He writes: 'as an ideological fact, it completely disappears: the bourgeoisie has obliterated its name in passing from reality to representation, from economic man to mental man' (1973:150). This is a class with no name because myth functions as ideology to ensure that it is not named. For example, the myth of the nation guarantees the anonymity of the bourgeoisie by representing everyone as citizens. More generally, bourgeois ideology focuses upon the figure of universal 'man', thereby dissolving the reality of social classes. He argues that 'the fact of the bourgeoisie becomes absorbed into an amorphous universe, whose sole inhabitant is Eternal Man, who is neither proletarian nor bourgeois.' He continues, 'the whole of France is steeped in this anonymous ideology...dependent on the representations which the bourgeoisie has and makes us have of the relations between man and the world' (ibid.: 153 and 152).

Barthes is therefore led to the conclusion that bourgeois ideology lies at the very heart of myth in modern society. 'The flight from the name "bourgeois"', Barthes insists, 'is not therefore an illusory, accidental, secondary, natural or

insignificant phenomenon.' Rather, 'it is bourgeois ideology itself, the process through which the bourgeoisie transforms the reality of the world into an image of the world, History into Nature.' He concludes that 'this image has a remarkable feature: it is upside down. The status of the bourgeoisie is particular, historical: man as represented by it is universal, eternal' (ibid.: 154). This is how Barthes understands myth. Myth transforms history into nature, which is exactly the function of bourgeois ideology. Myth thus facilitates the tasks of bourgeois ideology and represents the interests of the bourgeois class.

Barthes conducts a similar analysis of gender, and we can use this example to conclude our outline of semiology. Yet again he takes a photo in a magazine as an example. Since the signs of popular culture are, at first sight, self-evident and all around us, we don't have to look very far for examples of how myths work. For Barthes, it is partly because modern bourgeois society is flooded with cultural signs that semiology is so important. This time his example is of a photo of seventy women novelists. From Barthes's point of view, what is interesting is that these women are also identified by the number of children they have. The photograph and its caption denote a group of women writers who are also mothers. The connotation is, however, what interests Barthes. He identifies this as the attempt, by the sign of women as novelists and mothers, to make the role of women as mothers appear to be primary, natural and inevitable, whereas it is really historically and culturally specific. Women may succeed in being novelists, but the connotations of the photo and caption distort this to imply that women are more naturally concerned with motherhood. The photo and caption together form the signifier, the signified of which is the natural role of women to be mothers, irrespective of whatever else they do or aspire to do, such as being novelists.

'The eternal statute of womanhood' is used by Barthes to interpret this myth. He suggests this means that 'women are on the earth to give children to men.' They can 'write as much

as they like', they can 'decorate their condition, but above all', they cannot 'depart from it'. They can 'acquire self-confidence' and 'can very well have access, like men, to the superior status of creation'. However, men need to 'be quickly reassured: women will not be taken from them for all that, they will remain no less available for motherhood by nature' (ibid.: 56–57).

Myth is again seen by Barthes to transform history into nature. This time the role of women as mothers is made to appear natural and inevitable, the related connotation being that the power and dominance of men is equally natural and inevitable. The myth exhorts women as follows: 'Love, work, write, be business-women or women of letters, but always remember that man exists, and that you are not made like him; your order is free on condition that it depends on his; your freedom is a luxury, it is possible only if you first acknowledge the obligations of your nature' (ibid.: p. 58).

Structuralism and semiology: some key problems

We can now clarify and add to the problems which have already been raised about the perspectives discussed in this chapter. We can therefore look at some of the criticisms which can be made of Lévi-Strauss's structuralism and Barthes's semiology.

Lévi-Strauss's structuralism

A familiar complaint about Lévi-Strauss's ideas is that they lack empirical validity.⁹ A number of related criticisms can be made here. It can be claimed that Lévi-Strauss's theories are supported by a highly selective and very partial use of examples, that they are simply not based upon sufficient evidence or that they are so constructed as to be resistant to any kind of empirical refutation. These claims may appear strange in that Lévi-Strauss's work is full of examples, but critics insist that these are only admitted if they are favourable

to his case and divert attention away from cases which might refute his theories. For example, his analysis of totemism is only possible because he confines it to the study of myth, and does not consider how it works in relation to kinship systems. His analysis of Oedipal myths is only successful because he selects those features of the stories which suit his case, and ignores others which contradict the idea that they are expressions of a universal mental structure. Also, the myths he refers to may not be interpreted in the logical manner he suggests, but may be better understood by how they function in specific historical societies.

The argument that Lévi-Strauss ensures his theories are closed to empirical refutation is closely linked to the criticism that his ideas are too abstract and theoretical. His concern with the mental structure which lies behind the myths he studies leads him to engage in cerebral exercises rather than empirical research. His notion of structure can be regarded as so abstract that it allows him to reach the conclusions he does. The more abstract an idea is, the more vague it is, and thus the more closed it is to empirical refutation. This is closely linked to his definition of structure as a mental or psychic phenomenon. Lévi-Strauss's structuralism is marked by idealism and reductionism in that the variety and complexity of myths are reduced to the mental structure of the human mind. There are said to be two problems with this argument. First, it neglects the material processes of production whereby societies reproduce themselves, and thereby reproduce their cultures. Second, it reduces culture to a mental structure and so neglects its complexity and its historical and social specificity. It thus fails to provide an adequate explanation of this complexity and specificity, and cannot account for the things which it is trying to explain except by ignoring their specific character.

Another way of appreciating this problem is to look at the claim that structuralism presents an ahistorical approach to the study of culture. We have already seen how Saussure distinguishes between synchronic and diachronic analysis. We

have also seen how difficult it is to maintain this distinction in practice. It is difficult to disentangle the uses of language over time from the formal rules which are used by speakers at any particular point in time, and it is misleading to treat such rules as simply static and fixed norms. With Lévi-Strauss's work we confront this problem more directly in that he does not appear to recognise this distinction. His almost exclusive concern appears to be with synchronic analysis, uncovering the hidden and unconscious mental structure which gives rise to the myths we can observe. Insofar as his work dispenses with history, it confronts the same kind of difficulties experienced by Saussurian linguistics. Downplaying the importance of history means that the problems posed for any analysis of popular culture by historical variations in societies and cultures are simply not addressed. Indeed, it could be argued that it is impossible to understand the formal structures of language or myth outside of their social and historical contexts.

These problems are linked to the deterministic view structuralism has of the subject or human agency. The major determinant of cultural myths is the logical structure of the human mind, and this exerts its power irrespective of any particular social or historical context. It also exerts its power irrespective of the efforts of human subjects to impose their meanings on their social world, and to attempt to alter them in different ways. However, culture needs to be explained by human agency just as much as it needs to be explained by history. For example, the variations in meaning entailed in the production and consumption of culture tend not to support the contention that fixed and immutable universal oppositions make cultural myths possible. If meanings can be contested, human agency cannot be easily ignored.

The problems structuralism has in dealing with human agency can also be seen in the explanatory importance Lévi-Strauss attaches to the unconscious. As we have seen, the mental structure exerts its power irrespective of the role of subjects who are unaware of what is happening. Questions

can be raised about the empirical validity of this argument. How is it possible to validate the causal influence of something which is unconscious? If the mental structure remains unconscious we must presumably remain unaware of it, and cannot therefore talk about it in any meaningful empirical sense. Alternatively, if we can claim to demonstrate its existence how can it be unconscious?

Lastly, we can look at the difficulties associated with Lévi-Strauss's understanding of the binary opposition between nature and culture. He sees this as a basic logical opposition lying behind, and causing, the temporary reconciliations between nature and culture to be found in myths such as totemism. Yet how clear and basic is this opposition? How can it be conceived of as a component of a universal mental structure lying outside specific societies and cultures, when it can only be defined in cultural terms? The concept of nature within particular societies is not 'natural' but culturally defined. Lévi-Strauss does refer to the ways in which the distinction between nature and culture varies between societies, for example with respect to definitions of edible and inedible food (1970). However, rather than trying to account for this historically and sociologically, he reduces it to an invariant mental structure. Clearly all societies are confronted by a nature which they have to deal with. Therefore their cultural definitions of nature can be seen as the ways they understand nature and make it meaningful. Nature can never therefore be 'innocent'; it exists as a reality which is interpreted by a society's culture. This idea is in keeping with the arguments of semiology, which does not appear to deny the importance of culturally specific definitions of categories such as nature and culture.

Roland Barthes's semiology

Some might suggest that the semiology developed by Barthes is preferable to structuralism because it is historical and relates the signs of popular culture to social forces and class interests. Barthes's approach has had a major influence upon

studies of popular culture, but it faces certain problems which will be considered in closing this chapter.¹⁰

For a start, it is hard to say whether Barthes's analyses of myth fare any better than those of Lévi-Strauss when it comes to the problem of empirical validation. While semiology, like structuralism, is presented in principle (at least in Barthes's earlier work) as a rigorous scientific method, this is not carried over into its practice. What validity does Barthes's interpretation of a particular cultural item possess? He does not attempt to indicate why his interpretation is to be preferred to others.

For example, he suggests that roses signify passion. But how can he validate this conclusion, and say they should be understood in this way, and not as a way of signifying a joke, a farewell, or a platonic thank you? How do we discriminate between these interpretations? What evidence could a semiologist call upon to back up Barthes's interpretation? Similarly, semiologists are fond of referring to the codes which lie behind, or are embodied in, a particular sign or myth, but rarely if ever produce evidence of this code independently of the sign or myth under consideration. The fact that, later on, Barthes argues that texts are polysemic in being open to different interpretations hardly gets us very far.¹¹ Presumably, he is not arguing that texts are open to an infinite number of interpretations, nor that all interpretations are equally acceptable. So why should one interpretation be preferred to another? And why should some interpretations of signs be rejected?

This lack of attention to empirical validation is also evident in the problem semiology has in attributing meaning to myths. One of the aims of semiology is to show how the meaning attributed to a particular myth is systematic and not arbitrary. But it can be argued that the opposite is the case. Semiology wants to demonstrate that the meanings uncovered by its approach are systematic in that they possess a comprehensive structure and are prevalent within the society in which the myth is found. However, if the analysis is confined to the sign

itself and the problem of empirical validation is ignored, it is difficult to see how this claim can be substantiated. How do we know, for example, that the conclusions offered by semiology are not the result of the subjective impressions of the analyst but an objective uncovering of the systematic structure of meaning? Indeed, is semiology better viewed as a type of textual appreciation or literary criticism than as an objective social science?

A brief example will hopefully clarify this point. Williamson has tried to apply semiology to the analysis of magazine advertisements, and in her first analysis of an advert in her book, one for car tyres showing a car on a jetty, she writes:

the jetty is supposedly here as a test of braking power; it provides an element of risk.... However, the significance of the jetty is actually the opposite of risk and danger... the outside of the jetty resembles the outside of a tyre and the curve is suggestive of its shape...the jetty is tough and strong...because of the visual resemblance, we assume that this is true of the tyre as well. In the picture, the jetty actually encloses the car, protectively surrounding it with solidity in the middle of dangerous water; similarly, the whole safety of the car and driver is wrapped up in the tyre, which stands up to the elements and supports the car.

(Williamson 1978:18)

This analysis is dependent upon the idea that the jetty represents a place which is strong and safe, and that this is an expression of a wider cultural code. How else could the signification of the jetty work? But why should we assume that people will regard a jetty as a place of safety no matter how strong and secure it may appear? In fact, Williamson's attribution of meaning, which equates the jetty with safety, is totally arbitrary. Accordingly, the implication that it is indicative of a cultural code is unfounded.

There are some related problems associated with the semiological analysis of popular culture. Much is made of

Barthes's distinction between denotation and connotation. It is argued that myth works because we see the denotations of a particular sign or myth but its connotations remain hidden until they are revealed to us by a semiologist. Yet is there such a thing as pure denotation? Are not the connotations of a sign as clear as, if not sometimes more clear than, its denotations? Moreover, insofar as signs are interpreted by their connotations, without being backed up by independent evidence, there is no reason why the connotations of a particular sign should not be readily apparent. After all, Barthes sits down in the hairdresser's, sees the photo of the soldier on the cover of a magazine and quickly works out its connotations. How difficult is it then to make up the connotations of a myth on the spot? Can it be the case that connotations may not be so hidden or as difficult to see as semiologists argue?

As noted above, a major problem with the semiological study of signs is that it neglects the contexts in which signs are used to communicate. The question here is: Can signs be adequately understood if they are divorced from the contexts in which they are used and interpreted? For example, how can we know that a bunch of roses signifies passion unless we also know the intention of the sender and the reaction of the receiver, and the kind of relationship they are involved in? If they are lovers and accept the conventions of giving and receiving flowers as an aspect of romantic, sexual love, then we might accept Barthes's interpretation. But if we do this, we do so on the basis not of the sign but of the social relationships in which we can locate the sign. Moreover, if we accept the interpretation of the sign Barthes proposes (and he makes no attempt to indicate the social relationships in which it is to be found) how do we know that intentions and relationships are involved which are not about passion? The roses may also be sent as a joke, an insult, a sign of gratitude, and so on. They may indicate passion on the part of the sender but repulsion on the part of the receiver; they may signify family relations between grandparents and grandchildren rather than

relations between lovers, and so on. They might even connote sexual harassment. The point here is that it is impossible to interpret signs adequately unless their contexts of use, and the social relationships which confer meaning upon them, are taken into consideration. Semiology does not recognise that meaning is not a quality of the sign itself but of the social relationships in which it can be located.

This point can be taken further. Signs are implicated in social relationships in that they have to be produced in order to be culturally available as signs. (The use of roses to signify passion might be better understood as an example of how much 'love' has been commercialised.) A familiar complaint is that semiology ignores the context of production. Cultural signs, such as magazines, are produced by industries because of their marketability and profitability. They are among the commodities which are produced, circulated and consumed in a capitalist society. However, the semiological decoding of signs tends to ignore the context of industrial production.

This, in turn, raises the problem of the consumption of signs, the interpretations made of signs by the people at which they are directed. The key question here is, Why should the interpretation of signs and myths offered by semiology be accepted if they take no account of the interpretations placed upon them by their audiences? On what grounds can semiologists argue that their understanding of popular cultural signs is adequate if it neglects those groups who consume these signs? In part, this relates back to the fact that semiology fails to tackle the problem of justifying empirically its interpretations. In part, it also relates to the way semiology neglects the social relationships in which signs are produced and consumed. But it equally concerns how the meaningful character of popular culture can be determined. It would seem that this cannot be done without researching the part audiences play in arriving at interpretations of popular culture.

We have seen how Barthes has a fairly crude view of ideology. He sees it as working in the interests of the

bourgeoisie. It is this theory which introduces the concept of ideology into semiological analysis, since the connotations and signifieds of signs are, in the end, reduced to bourgeois ideology.¹² To appreciate the dubious nature of this theory of ideology it is necessary to take into consideration the arguments of the next chapter.

Further reading

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